GEOGRAPHY IN HISTORY

3.2 Differences Between North and South

MAIN IDEA At the start of the Civil War, the Union and the Confederacy each had important geographic advantages.

GEOGRAPHIC ADVANTAGES

Geography is critically important in any war. Mountains and rivers can serve as natural defenses, helping an army to defend itself from invaders. Hills can provide a visual advantage for soldiers who are watching for enemy troops. Trees felled in a forest can slow down an army as it tries to pass through.

In the Civil War, the Union and the Confederacy had other types of geographic advantages. You've learned that the Union had a greater population spread across a wide geographic area, which helped boost the size of its army. It also had many industrial centers. As you know, too, the Confederacy had the advantage of fighting the war on familiar terrain. And the South grew abundant cotton, which could be sold to help cover Confederate war expenses.

Read the following text and examine the maps to see how four important geographical factors—population, railroads, industry, and agriculture—critically affected the Civil War.

POPULATION

In 1860, the North had a population of about 18.5 million people, of which about 3.8 million free men were of military age. In contrast, the South had about 5.5 million free persons and 3.5 million enslaved people. Only 1.1 million free men were of military age, and 80 percent of these went to war. This percentage reflects the South's dedication to the cause for independence, since Jefferson Davis and the Confederacy relied on the voluntary cooperation of state governments for troops.

Additionally, 19 of the largest cities in the United States were part of the Union. Because the South was an agricultural society with few industrial cities to attract large populations, the Confederacy had only two, New Orleans and Charleston.

RAIL TRANSPORTATION

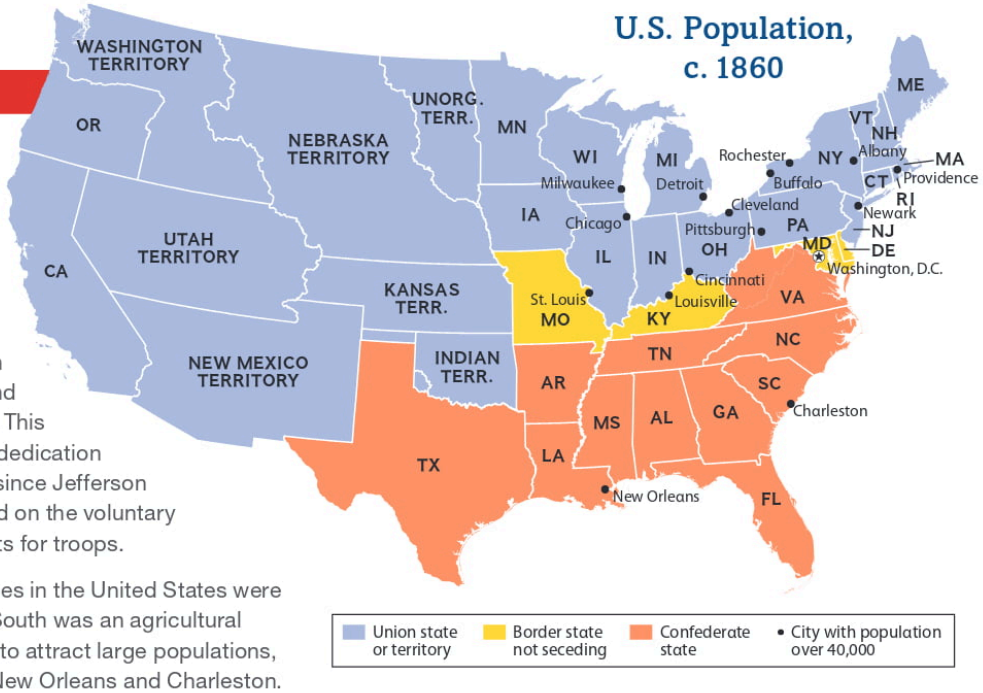
As you can see on the large map, the Union had more than twice as many miles of railroad lines as the Confederacy. In the South, most railroads went from Mississippi, Alabama, and Georgia to Charleston, carrying cotton for exporting.

The Civil War was one of the first wars in which railroads played a critical role. The Union and the Confederacy both used railroads to ship equipment, weapons, and troops. Sometimes, officers even sent spies on trains to learn about the opponent's troop movements. However, the Confederacy began the war at a disadvantage. Their railroads were in bad shape, and repairs often had to wait. Many railroad workers had quit to fight the war.

INDUSTRY

Manufacturing, especially of iron and steel, was critically important to both the Union and the Confederacy during the Civil War. The large map shows the location of factories in the North and the South. As you've learned, the majority of the factories were in the North, but the Confederacy did have some in Virginia and other states. The largest Confederate iron works was in Richmond, Virginia. Confederate officers fought to protect their factories because they were so important to the South.

Because the Union did more manufacturing, it was able to produce more of the rifles, cannons, railroad tracks, locomotives, and other materials its army needed for war. That was a definite advantage.



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AGRICULTURE

As the map above shows, cotton was king in the South. The region devoted the majority of its economic and technological energy to this cash crop. As a result, the South supplied most of the world's cotton, producing 77 percent of the cotton used by Great Britain, the largest maker of textiles in the world.

Cotton was critical to the Confederacy's ability to raise the huge amounts of money needed to fight a war. In addition to Great Britain, the South exported cotton to France and other European countries and used the profits to buy weapons and equipment and to fund the Confederate government. Even textile mills in the North bought cotton from the South. The Confederacy also borrowed against the promise of future cotton crops to pay for its war efforts.

THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

1. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What geographic advantages did the Confederacy have, and why were they important?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the Union's superiority in rail transportation contribute to its victory in the war?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** In your opinion, what was the most important geographic factor in the outcome of the war?

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